

AP U.S. GOVERNMENT & POLITICS · THE UNIVERSAL STUDY GUIDE

Targeting a 3, 4, or 5 — every concept tagged for your tier

Tier badges: [3] foundational · [4] adds for 4+ · [5] adds for 5

Targeting a 4 → study [3] AND [4] items. Targeting a 5 → study all three tiers.

PAGE 1 | MATH OF 3/4/5 · 5 UNITS · REQUIRED 9 + 15

About this exam. AP Gov has a UNIQUE feature among AP exams: **9 required foundational documents + 15 required SCOTUS cases**. These appear by name on FRQs and you must know them. Beyond that, 5 units cover foundations, branches, civil liberties/rights, ideology, and political participation.

THE MATH OF YOUR TARGET

Target	MCQ (55q, 50%)	FRQ (4q, 50%)	Approx %	Tier
3 (PASS)	~28-32 / 55	~12/24 raw	~50-55%	[3]
4	~36-40 / 55	~16/24 raw	~62-67%	[3] + [4]
5	~44-48 / 55	~20/24 raw	~78-82%	All

Time: 80 min for 55 MCQ (~1:27 each), 100 min for 4 FRQs. **All 4 FRQs have FIXED structure:** Concept Application (Q1), Quantitative Analysis (Q2), SCOTUS Comparison (Q3), Argument Essay (Q4). Each is a different beast — practice each format separately.

THE 5 UNITS — by exam weight

#	Unit	Weight	Focus
1	Foundations of American Democracy	15–22%	Constitution, federalism, founding documents, types of democracy
2	Interactions Among Branches	25–36%	Largest unit. Congress, President, Courts, bureaucracy
3	Civil Liberties & Civil Rights	13–18%	Bill of Rights, 14th Amendment, selective incorporation, key cases
4	American Political Ideologies & Beliefs	10–15%	Conservative vs liberal, polling, socialization
5	Political Participation	20–27%	Voting, parties, elections, interest groups, media, campaign finance

KEY INSIGHT [3] Unit 2 alone is 25-36% of the exam. Master Congress, President, Court, bureaucracy — how they CHECK each other. Most MCQs and FRQs hit unit 2 + 5 (the largest two).

3 KEY POLITICAL VALUES (in tension) [3]/[4]

Value	What it captures
Liberty / individual freedom [3]	Protect individuals from government tyranny. Roots: Locke, natural rights.
Order / stability [3] / [4]	Government's responsibility to maintain society. Roots: Hobbes, federalists.
Equality [3] / [4]	Of opportunity (most agree on) vs of outcome (contested). 14th Amendment, civil rights laws.

[5] FRQs love asking about TENSIONS between values — liberty vs order (Patriot Act), liberty vs equality (affirmative action), federal vs state (immigration). Frame your essay around the tension.

PAGE 2 | UNIT 1: FOUNDATIONS — CONSTITUTION · FEDERALISM

Forms of Democracy [3]/[4]

Type	Description
Participatory [3]	Direct citizen involvement. Town meetings, ballot initiatives, referenda.
Pluralist [3]/[4]	Group competition (interest groups). Many groups → balanced policy. <i>Federalist 10</i> favors this.
Elite [4]	Small group of educated/wealthy elites have disproportionate power. Mills, Mosca.

Constitution structure [3]/[4]

ARTICLE I – Legislative (Congress, longest article – most powers)
 ARTICLE II – Executive (President)
 ARTICLE III – Judicial (Supreme Court + lower courts)
 ARTICLE IV – States, full faith & credit
 ARTICLE V – Amendment process (2/3 to propose + 3/4 to ratify)
 ARTICLE VI – Supremacy clause (federal law trumps state law)
 ARTICLE VII – Ratification (9 of 13 needed)

BILL OF RIGHTS (1791) – first 10 amendments. Demanded by Anti-Federalists.

Federalism [3]/[4]/[5]

Concept	What it means
Enumerated powers [3]	Listed specifically for FEDERAL government in Article I, Sec 8. Coin money, declare war, regulate interstate commerce.
Reserved powers [3]	Powers reserved to STATES via 10th Amendment. Education, marriage, intra-state commerce.
Concurrent powers [3]	Both federal AND states have. Tax, build roads, courts.
Necessary & Proper Clause [3]/[4]	"Elastic clause" — Congress can do what's needed to execute enumerated powers. Source of IMPLIED powers.
Commerce Clause [4]	Federal regulates interstate commerce. Hugely expanded federal power 20th c.
Supremacy Clause [3]	Federal law > state law when in conflict (Article VI).
14th Amendment [4]	Equal protection + due process — applied to STATES. Foundation of selective incorporation.

Federalism evolution [4]/[5]

- **Dual federalism** ("layer cake") [4] = states + federal in separate spheres. Pre-1937.
- **Cooperative federalism** ("marble cake") [4] = blended responsibilities. New Deal onward.
- **Fiscal federalism** [4]/[5]: federal grants tied to state compliance. **Categorical grants** (specific purposes) vs **block grants** (broad purposes, more state discretion).
- **Mandates** [4]: federal rules states must follow. **Unfunded mandates** (states pay) controversial.

KEY INSIGHT [5] **The federalism balance has shifted.** New Deal + Civil Rights expanded federal power. Reagan era pushed back ("new federalism," devolution). Marriage equality, Obamacare = recent flashpoints. Frame any federalism FRQ around this OSCILLATION.

PAGE 3 | UNIT 2: CONGRESS · PRESIDENT · COURTS · BUREAUCRACY**Congress [3]/[4]**

	House (435)	Senate (100)
Term	2 years	6 years (1/3 every 2 yrs)
Constituency	District (~750K people)	Whole state
Leader	Speaker of the House	VP (tiebreaker) + President pro tempore
Unique powers	Originate revenue bills, impeach	Approve treaties (2/3), confirm appointments, try impeachments
Style	Strict rules, faster, partisan	Filibuster (60 to break), more deliberative

- **How a bill becomes law [3]**: introduced → committee → floor vote → other chamber → conference committee (if needed) → both chambers' final vote → president (sign / veto / pocket veto).
- **Filibuster + cloture [4]**: Senate-only. 60 votes to invoke cloture and end filibuster (except for judicial nominations now).
- **Gerrymandering [3]/[4]**: redrawing districts for partisan advantage. Cracking + packing. Limited by *Shaw v. Reno* (race-based unconstitutional) but partisan gerrymandering largely allowed (*Rucho v. Common Cause* 2019).

Presidency [3]/[4]**FORMAL POWERS (Article II):**

Veto bills, command military, make treaties (Senate confirms), nominate judges, grant pardons, give State of the Union

INFORMAL POWERS (developed over time):

Bully pulpit (public speech) Executive orders (without Congress)
 Executive agreements (no Senate) Signing statements
 Going public (TV/social media) War Powers (esp. since 1945)

CHECKS ON PRESIDENT:

Congress: override veto (2/3), impeach, control budget, refuse confirmation
 Court: judicial review can strike down executive orders

Courts [3]/[4]

- **Judicial review [3]/[4]** = power to strike down laws as unconstitutional. Established by **Marbury v. Madison (1803)**.
- **Court selection [3]/[4]**: nominated by President, confirmed by Senate. Lifetime appointment.
- **Judicial activism vs restraint [4]/[5]**: Activism = court more willing to overturn precedent / strike down laws. Restraint = defer to elected branches.
- **Stare decisis [4]** = follow precedent. *Roe v. Wade* overturned 2022 (*Dobbs*) — controversial precisely because it broke this norm.
- **How cases reach SCOTUS [4]**: writ of certiorari. "Rule of 4" — 4 justices must agree to hear case. Out of ~7,000 petitions/year, ~80 heard.

Bureaucracy [3]/[4]

- **Cabinet [3]** = 15 executive departments (State, Treasury, Defense, etc.) + heads ("Secretaries").
- **Independent agencies [3]/[4]**: NASA, CIA, EPA — outside cabinet structure.
- **Independent regulatory commissions [4]**: Fed, SEC, FCC, FTC. Multi-member boards, fixed terms — protected from president.
- **Iron triangles [4]/[5]**: alliance of (1) bureaucratic agency, (2) congressional committee, (3) interest group. Mutually beneficial. **Issue networks** = looser, more diverse coalitions.
- **Discretionary authority [4]** = bureaucrats fill in gaps when laws are vague ("reasonable accommodation" — what does that mean exactly?).

PAGE 4 | UNIT 3: CIVIL LIBERTIES & CIVIL RIGHTS

Civil liberties = limits ON government (what it CANNOT do to you). **Civil rights** = government PROTECTIONS (against discrimination, ensuring equal treatment).

Bill of Rights essentials [3]/[4]

- 1st – Speech, press, religion (free exercise + establishment), assembly, petition
- 2nd – Right to bear arms
- 3rd – No quartering of soldiers (rarely tested)
- 4th – No unreasonable search/seizure (probable cause + warrants)
- 5th – Due process, no self-incrimination, no double jeopardy, eminent domain w/ compensation
- 6th – Speedy public trial, confront accusers, right to counsel
- 7th – Civil jury trial
- 8th – No cruel + unusual punishment, no excessive bail
- 9th – Unenumerated rights retained by people
- 10th – Powers not delegated reserved to states

Selective Incorporation [4]/[5]

The 14th Amendment's due process clause has been used to **APPLY most of the Bill of Rights to the STATES** — case by case. Originally Bill of Rights only restricted FEDERAL government.

- **[4] Most rights now incorporated** (apply to state action). Notable holdouts: 3rd Amendment, 7th Amendment, grand jury indictment requirement.
- **[5] *Gideon v. Wainwright* (1963)** = right to attorney (6th) incorporated to states. *McDonald v. Chicago* (2010) = 2nd Amendment incorporated.

First Amendment — religion + speech [3]/[4]

Issue	Test / framework
Establishment Clause [3]/[4]	<i>Engel v. Vitale</i> (1962) — school prayer unconstitutional. Government can't endorse religion.
Free Exercise Clause [3]/[4]	<i>Wisconsin v. Yoder</i> (1972) — Amish exempt from compulsory education past 8th grade. Sincere religious belief gets accommodation when government interest weak.
Speech — content-based restrictions [4]	Strict scrutiny. <i>Tinker v. Des Moines</i> (1969) — students don't shed rights at schoolhouse gate (armbands).
Time, place, manner restrictions [4]	OK if content-neutral, narrowly tailored, leave alternatives.
Press [4]	<i>NYT v. United States</i> (1971) — prior restraint disfavored (Pentagon Papers).
Symbolic speech [4]	<i>Tinker + Texas v. Johnson</i> (1989, flag burning protected).

Civil Rights [3]/[4]

- **14th Amendment Equal Protection Clause [3]** = government cannot deny equal protection of laws. Foundation for civil rights.
- **Brown v. Board of Education (1954) [3]/[4]** = school segregation violates Equal Protection. Overturned *Plessy*.
- **Civil Rights Act of 1964 [3]** = banned racial/sex discrimination in public accommodations + employment.
- **Voting Rights Act of 1965 [3]** = banned literacy tests + provided federal oversight in discriminatory states. Weakened by *Shelby County v. Holder* (2013).
- **Title IX (1972) [4]** = banned sex discrimination in federally funded education.
- **Affirmative action [4]/[5]**: race-conscious admissions/employment to remedy past discrimination. *Grutter v. Bollinger* (2003) allowed; *Students for Fair Admissions v. Harvard* (2023) overturned *Grutter*.

KEY INSIGHT [5] Levels of scrutiny [5]. Different classifications get different judicial review: **Strict scrutiny** (race, national origin) — gov must show compelling interest + narrowly tailored. **Intermediate scrutiny** (sex) — must serve important interest. **Rational basis** (everything else) — easy bar to meet.

PAGE 5 | UNIT 4: AMERICAN IDEOLOGIES & BELIEFS**Liberal vs Conservative [3]/[4]**

Issue	Liberal	Conservative
Economic role of govt	More regulation, social safety net, progressive taxation	Less regulation, lower taxes, free market
Social issues	Pro-choice, LGBTQ+ rights, gun control, criminal justice reform	Pro-life, traditional family, 2nd Amendment, law-and-order
Foreign policy	Multilateral, diplomacy-first, soft power	Unilateral, military strength, hard power
Federal vs state	Stronger federal government	Devolution, states' rights

[4] Reality is complex. Many Americans are SOCIALLY conservative + ECONOMICALLY liberal (or vice versa). "Libertarians" = small government on BOTH economic + social. Don't assume linear left-right spectrum.

Political Socialization [3]/[4]

- **Family [3]** = strongest single influence on early ideology. Children often inherit parents' party identification.
- **Schools [3]/[4]** = civic education, citizenship norms, exposure to diverse views.
- **Peers + media [3]/[4]** = adolescence + young adulthood. Now: heavy social media influence.
- **Generational effects [4]** = formative events shape lifelong views (Great Depression → New Deal Democrats; Reagan/9-11 generations differ).
- **Geographic [4]** = urban (more liberal) vs rural (more conservative); coastal vs heartland.

Public Opinion Polling [3]/[4]/[5]**GOOD POLLS HAVE:**

1. RANDOM SAMPLE (every adult equal chance of selection)
2. SAMPLE SIZE adequate (~1000 for ±3% margin of error)
3. NEUTRAL question wording
4. RESPONDENT ANONYMITY (reduces social desirability bias)

BAD POLLS:

- Self-selection (online polls, write-ins)
- Leading questions ("Do you support the failed administration's...")
- Small sample (high MOE)

MARGIN OF ERROR: typical ±3%. Two candidates within MOE = "statistical tie."

Economic policy debates [4]/[5]

- **Keynesian (liberal lean) [4]/[5]:** government spending in recessions stimulates demand. New Deal foundations.
- **Supply-side / monetarist (conservative lean) [4]/[5]:** tax cuts + low regulation incentivize production. Reagan, Friedman.
- **Fiscal vs monetary [4]:** Fiscal = Congress + President (taxes + spending). Monetary = Federal Reserve (interest rates + money supply).

KEY INSIGHT [5] Polarization is real but uneven. ELITES (politicians, partisans) are more polarized than ordinary voters. Most Americans are "sorting" — fewer cross-pressured voters than 1960s. Useful frame for FRQs about parties + Congress dysfunction.

PAGE 6 | UNIT 5: PARTICIPATION — VOTING · PARTIES · ELECTIONS · MEDIA**Voting [3]/[4]**

AMENDMENTS expanding voting:

- 15th (1870) – race
- 19th (1920) – women
- 24th (1964) – banned poll taxes
- 26th (1971) – 18-year-olds

VOTING ACT OF 1965 – banned literacy tests, federal oversight

MOTOR VOTER ACT (1993) – register at DMV

HELP AMERICA VOTE ACT (2002) – post-2000 reforms

Why people vote (or don't) [3]/[4]

- **Predictors of voting [3]/[4]:** education (highest correlation), age, income, race (white higher than Black higher than Latino historically), home ownership, partisan strength.
- **Barriers [3]/[4]:** registration deadlines, voter ID laws, polling place access, time off work.
- **Rational choice [4]/[5]:** marginal cost vs marginal benefit. For a single vote, math says don't vote. People vote anyway → "civic duty" hypothesis.
- **Voter turnout US [3]/[4]:** presidential ~60-65%, midterms ~40-45%, primaries lower. **LOW vs other developed democracies** (UK ~67%, Australia ~92% — compulsory).

Political parties [3]/[4]

- **Functions [3]:** recruit candidates, organize campaigns, run primaries, link voters to government.
- **Realignments [4]/[5]** = lasting shifts in party coalitions. 1932 (FDR coalition), 1968+ (South switched R), 2016 (working-class whites + non-college).
- **Party-in-government, party-in-electorate, party-as-organization [4]** = three faces.
- **Two-party system [3]/[4]** persistence: single-member plurality ("first past the post") = Duverger's law → minor parties marginalized.
- **Third parties [4]:** rarely win, but can SPOIL elections (Perot 1992, Nader 2000) or push major parties (Roosevelt 1912 → Progressives).

Elections [3]/[4]

PRIMARY ELECTIONS – pick the party's nominee

Closed: only registered party members vote

Open: any voter, but only one party's primary

Caucus: in-person discussion-based (Iowa, NV)

ELECTORAL COLLEGE (presidential):

538 electors (= 435 House + 100 Senate + 3 DC)

Need 270 to win

Almost all states: WINNER-TAKE-ALL (except ME + NE)

Can WIN POPULAR VOTE + LOSE EC (2000 Gore, 2016 H. Clinton)

CAMPAIGN FINANCE:

PACs – Political Action Committees (limited contribution caps)

Super PACs – UNLIMITED (since Citizens United, 2010), but no coordination with candidates

Hard money (regulated, to candidates) vs Soft money (party / issue ads)

Media [3]/[4]

- **Linkage institution [3]** = connects citizens to government. So are parties + interest groups + elections.
- **Agenda-setting [4]** = media decides WHAT issues we discuss.
- **Framing [4]** = HOW issues are presented.
- **Horse-race coverage [4]** = focus on poll numbers + strategy over policy substance. Common election critique.
- **Modern fragmentation [4]/[5]:** social media + cable news → echo chambers, partisan media (Fox, MSNBC), declining trust in mainstream.

Interest groups [3]/[4]

- **Tactics [3]:** lobbying, campaign contributions, grassroots mobilization, litigation, amicus briefs.
- **Iron triangles** (recap from Unit 2).
- **Pluralism vs elite theory [4]/[5]:** are groups balanced (pluralism) or do well-funded groups dominate (elitism)? Olson's "collective action problem" — small concentrated groups beat large diffuse ones.

PAGE 7 | THE 9 REQUIRED FOUNDATIONAL DOCUMENTS

Memorize these 9 by name + main argument. They appear on FRQs by name — Q3 (SCOTUS Comparison) sometimes uses them; Q4 (Argument) lists 3 to choose for evidence.

Document	Year	Main argument / function
Declaration of Independence	1776	Natural rights, social contract, justification for separation from Britain. "All men created equal" + Locke's life/liberty/pursuit of happiness.
Articles of Confederation	1781	First US government — weak central, strong states. Failed → Constitution.
U.S. Constitution	1787	The fundamental law. Separation of powers, federalism, checks and balances.
Federalist No. 10	1787 (Madison)	Defense of large republic. Many factions in big country = no single faction tyrannizes. Pluralism.
Federalist No. 51	1788 (Madison)	Separation of powers + checks. "If men were angels, no government would be necessary." Ambition vs ambition.
Federalist No. 70	1788 (Hamilton)	Energetic single executive. Defends strong, unified presidency vs plural executive.
Federalist No. 78	1788 (Hamilton)	Judicial review + lifetime tenure. Court is "least dangerous branch" — has neither sword nor purse.
Brutus No. 1	1787 (Anti-Fed)	Anti-Federalist response. Warning that strong federal government → tyranny in large republic. Bill of Rights needed.
Letter from Birmingham Jail	1963 (MLK)	Justifies civil disobedience. Distinguishes just vs unjust laws. Direct action when negotiation fails. Replied to white moderate clergy.

KEY INSIGHT [5] Pair documents that conflict. Federalist 10 (large republic protects liberty via factions) vs Brutus 1 (large republic = tyranny). Federalist 70 (strong executive) vs concerns of monarchical power. THIS SHOWS DEPTH on FRQs.

PAGE 8 | THE 15 REQUIRED SCOTUS CASES

Memorize each case's name + year + clause/issue + holding + significance. Q3 (SCOTUS Comparison) presents a NON-required case + asks you to compare to a required one.

Case	Year	Holding + significance
Marbury v. Madison	1803	Established judicial review — Court can strike down laws as unconstitutional. Foundational.
McCulloch v. Maryland	1819	Necessary & Proper Clause allows Congress to charter national bank. Federal supremacy. Implied powers.
Schenck v. United States	1919	Clear & present danger test — speech NOT protected if creates danger ("shouting fire in a crowded theater"). 1st Amendment limits.
Brown v. Board of Education	1954	14th Amendment Equal Protection — segregation in schools unconstitutional. Overturned <i>Plessy</i> .
Baker v. Carr	1962	One person, one vote — federal courts can rule on apportionment. Ended legislative malapportionment.
Engel v. Vitale	1962	Establishment Clause — state-sponsored school prayer unconstitutional.
Gideon v. Wainwright	1963	6th Amendment right to counsel applies to states (incorporation). Indigent get appointed lawyer.
Tinker v. Des Moines	1969	1st Amendment symbolic speech — students wearing armbands protected. "Students don't shed rights at schoolhouse gate."
NYT v. United States	1971	1st Amendment press, prior restraint — Pentagon Papers published. Government can't preemptively block press.
Wisconsin v. Yoder	1972	Free Exercise — Amish exempt from school past 8th grade. Religious accommodation.
Roe v. Wade	1973	14th Amendment due process privacy → abortion right. OVERTURNED in 2022 by Dobbs. (Note: still required-knowledge for context.)
Shaw v. Reno	1993	14th Amendment Equal Protection — race-based gerrymandering subject to strict scrutiny. Bizarre district shapes suspect.
United States v. Lopez	1995	Commerce Clause LIMIT — Gun Free School Zones Act invalid (didn't substantially affect interstate commerce). First major commerce-clause federal limit since 1937.
McDonald v. Chicago	2010	2nd Amendment INCORPORATED to states via 14th Amendment due process. Cities can't ban handguns.
Citizens United v. FEC	2010	1st Amendment — corporations + unions have free speech rights → unlimited independent expenditures. Created Super PACs.

KEY INSIGHT [4] Q3 SCOTUS Comparison tactic. They give you a case you DON'T know. Identify the constitutional clause. Match it to a REQUIRED case using the same clause. Compare reasoning + holdings. The comparison framework matters more than getting all facts of the new case right.

PAGE 9 | FRQ STRATEGY — THE 4 FIXED FORMATS**Q1: CONCEPT APPLICATION (3 pts) [3]/[4]**

Read scenario → apply 3 concepts. A/B/C parts each ask you to: identify a concept OR explain how the scenario relates OR explain how something might result. Each = 1 sentence.

TIP: Address each part SEPARATELY. Label A, B, C.
Use the EXACT term from the prompt + define it.
Apply specifically to the scenario ("In this scenario, ...")

Q2: QUANTITATIVE ANALYSIS (4 pts) [3]/[4]

Read a graph/table → 4-part analysis. Identify a trend → describe a pattern → draw a conclusion → connect to a political concept.

- [3] **Always cite specific data** ("the table shows X% in 2010, rising to Y% in 2020").
- [3] **Use comparison language** ("compared to," "in contrast," "similar to").
- [4] **Part D is the hardest** — connecting numbers to a political concept (federalism, ideology, polarization). Practice this jump.

Q3: SCOTUS COMPARISON (4 pts) [3]/[4]/[5]

You're given a NON-required case + brief description. Compare to a REQUIRED case.

PART A: Identify the CLAUSE/CONSTITUTIONAL ISSUE (1 pt)
"Both cases involve the [Equal Protection / 1st Amendment Free Speech] clause."

PART B: Provide FACTS of required case + how they relate (2 pts)
"In Brown v. Board (1954), plaintiffs argued school segregation violated Equal Protection. Like the new case, both involve government discrimination on the basis of..."

PART C: Explain how the holding affects something (1 pt)
Often: "This decision could affect [policy area] by..."

Q4: ARGUMENT ESSAY (6 pts) [4]/[5]

Take a position on a political question. Defend with: 1 required document + 1 piece of additional evidence. Address counter-claim.

RUBRIC (6 pts):

1. **THESIS:** defensible claim (1)
2. **EVIDENCE PIECE 1:** from required document, in context (1)
3. **EVIDENCE PIECE 2:** from another required doc OR from your knowledge (1)
4. **EVIDENCE → ARGUMENT:** explain HOW evidence supports thesis (1)
5. **RESPOND TO OPPOSING/ALTERNATIVE perspective** (1)
6. **COMPLEX UNDERSTANDING:** nuance, counter-rebuttal, multiple perspectives (1)

KEY INSIGHT [5] The Q4 essay = the most rubric-able FRQ. All 6 points are checklist items. Hit each one explicitly: 'My thesis is...', 'According to Federalist 10...', 'However, those who disagree might argue X. Yet this overlooks Y because...'. Don't bury rubric points in vague prose.

PAGE 10 | SCORE LADDER · TIER CHECKLISTS · THE ONE THING

THE SCORE LADDER

For a 3 (Pass)	For a 4	For a 5
MCQ: 28-32 / 55	MCQ: 36-40 / 55	MCQ: 44-48 / 55
Q1 Concept App: 2/3 parts.	Q1: 3/3.	Q1: 3/3 + tightly contextual.
Q2 Quant: cite data + simple trend.	Q2: trend + comparison + concept connection.	Q2: 4/4 with sophisticated political analysis.
Q3 SCOTUS: identify clause + name a case.	Q3: full facts of required case + comparison.	Q3: comparison + impact analysis.
Q4 Argument: thesis + evidence + simple counter.	Q4: full rubric except complex understanding.	Q4: all 6 points.
Know 4-5 SCOTUS cases + 4-5 documents well.	Know all 9 documents + 10 cases.	All 9 docs + all 15 cases + tensions between them.

TIER-SPECIFIC TEST-DAY CHECKLISTS

For a 3 — focus only on these:

- ✓ MCQ: 28+ correct.
- ✓ Know the 9 unit-1 "big ideas": federalism, separation of powers, checks and balances, limited government.
- ✓ Memorize at least 5 SCOTUS cases: Marbury, McCulloch, Brown, Tinker, Citizens United.
- ✓ Q1: address each part separately with a sentence each.
- ✓ Q4: clear thesis + 2 evidence + brief counter.

For a 4 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 36+ correct.
- ✓ Memorize all 15 SCOTUS cases by year + clause + holding.
- ✓ Memorize all 9 documents by main argument.
- ✓ Q2: connect numbers to political concept in part D.
- ✓ Q3: compare the required case's reasoning explicitly to the new case.
- ✓ Use specific terms: filibuster, cloture, gerrymandering, iron triangle, etc.

For a 5 — add these on top:

- ✓ MCQ: 44+ correct.
- ✓ Q4: hit all 6 rubric points; address counter-rebuttal explicitly.
- ✓ Pair conflicting documents (Federalist 10 vs Brutus 1).
- ✓ Frame answers around tensions (liberty vs order, federal vs state).
- ✓ Distinguish levels of scrutiny + selective incorporation.
- ✓ Discuss recent applications (Citizens United → Super PACs, Shelby County → voter ID laws).

THE ONE THING THAT MATTERS MOST [3][4][5]: NAME THE DOCUMENT, NAME THE CASE, NAME THE CLAUSE. AP Gov rewards specificity. "The government can't do that" earns 0. "Under the 1st Amendment's Free Exercise clause, *Wisconsin v. Yoder* (1972) established that sincere religious beliefs warrant accommodation when compelling government interest is weak — applying here would suggest..." earns full credit. Always: NAME the case, document, clause, OR amendment. Vague generalities lose; specific names win.

If you do nothing else: master the 9 documents + 15 cases by name + clause + holding. That's the AP Gov formula.

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